Dimitar and Konstantin Miladinov — Bulgarian Folk Songs (1861)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Dimitar and Konstantin Miladinov, the sons of the Struga potter Hristo Miladinov, who gathered the songs of their people into one great book. Konstantin found a patron in Bishop Josip Juraj Strossmayer, and saw *Bulgarian Folk Songs* printed at Zagreb in June 1861. Within months both brothers had been arrested as alleged Russian agents. Konstantin, who went to Constantinople to free Dimitar, was himself arrested there. Both died of typhus in a Constantinople prison within days of each other, Konstantin on 7 January 1862 and Dimitar on 11 January 1862, months after their book appeared.

The author's own terms

The brothers called the collecting land “Western Bulgaria” in their announcements, because they disliked the name *Macedonia* as a Greek term. Konstantin set out that reasoning in a letter to Georgi Rakovski in January 1861. The term is theirs, in their own sense, and it is not silently modernised here.

The story

Dimitar Miladinov (1810–1862), the eldest of eight children, was educated at the Monastery of Saint Naum, at Ohrid, and in Ioannina. He taught in Ohrid, Struga, Bitola, Prilep, Magarevo and Kukush, pressing for Bulgarian-language schooling against the Greek-language establishment. Konstantin (1830–1862), the youngest son, studied under Dimitar, then at Ioannina and Athens, and from 1856 at Moscow University, where he studied Slavic philology and wrote *T'ga za jug* ("Longing for the South"). Dimitar had recorded the songs in Greek letters. Konstantin transcribed them into Cyrillic, failed to find a publisher in Russia, and found his patron in Strossmayer. Denounced by Bishop Meletius as a Russian agent, Dimitar was imprisoned in Constantinople in 1861. Konstantin went there to free him and was arrested on 5 August 1861. Whether the brothers ever saw each other again is unknown.

The work and what survives

Bulgarian Folk Songs (Zagreb: A. Jakić, 1861) holds 660 folk songs, together with folk legends, traditions, rituals, names, riddles and proverbs, collected mainly between 1854 and 1860. Most were collected by Dimitar, and most were recited by women. The districts run from Sofia and Panagyurishte in the east to Strumica, Kukush, Voden, Kostur, Veles, Debar, Prilep, Ohrid, Struga and Bitola in the west. Named singers include Depa Kavaeva of Struga, with close to 150 songs, Gyurgya Koteva of Prilep, and Hadzhi Maria Tomova of Panagyurishte. A third brother, Naum (1817–1897), helped compile the collection and wrote a biography of his brothers that he failed to publish. Later editions followed in 1891 (Dimitar's widow Mitra), 1942 (Mihail Arnaudov), and 1961 (Petar Dinekov). Konstantin's own poems survive at about fifteen. What this project holds is a fresh English draft of the heroic songs only — songs 57–203, 147 headings, Volume 1 of two projected volumes — made from the photographic text of the 1861 printing through machine OCR, worked over by hand, and labelled a working draft, not a critical edition. The rest is not in the folder.

Its English fortunes

The corrected finding, at exactly this strength, is: **no complete English collection found after research; the nine songs Elias Riggs Englished in 1862 are the earliest Englishing traced**. Riggs, an American linguist in

Constantinople, sent his nine songs in June 1862 to the American Oriental Society in Princeton, New Jersey. Later partial Englishings followed. *The Shade of the Balkans* (London: D. Nutt, 1904), associated with Pencho Slaveikoff, Henry Bernard and E. J. Dillon, rendered Bulgarian folk songs and proverbs into English, with 101 poems and 101 proverbs on its Internet Archive description; whether its songs came specifically from the 1861 texts was not pinned. Christopher Buxton's *Flowers Don't Grow Singly* (2016) is described by its reviewer as having, among its earliest poems, folk songs collected by the brothers in Buxton's translations. Parts of the collection were also translated into Czech, Russian and German.

What completing it would take

Completing the work, on the folder's two-volume plan, would mean Volume 2: songs 1–56 and 204–660 — 513 songs — plus the non-song material printed after the songs. Until that is done, every claim must be bounded to the heroic songs. The draft was made through machine OCR of the old type, with difficult and dialect-defeated places flagged rather than hidden. A Bulgarian-reading reviser working against the Library of Congress scan of the 1861 printing is needed to mend those places, with a final audit and editorial ruling before any presentation.

Sources

- Project folder: ~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/miladinov-bulgarian-folk-songs-heroic/
- https://www.loc.gov/item/2021666571/
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Miladinov_brothers
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Bulgarian_Folk_Songs
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- https://www.mytwostotinki.com/?tag=bulgarianliteraturemonth